COMMONS RESEARCH · MULTIPLAYER AI

Multiplayer AI: the shared run, not the shared chat

Research brief · 6 Oct 2026 · Companion to the Layer C brief and the strategy & roadmap · Links: research/multiplayer-ai-sources.md · † = secondary or vendor-reported

The text you pasted is **Y Combinator's Fall 2026 Request for Startups, "Multiplayer AI"**, by partner Aaron Epstein. It argues that AI hasn't had its Google Docs moment. Work with agents still happens "in a box only you can see", and the most a teammate can get is a read-only transcript. The market has moved since then:

- In 10 months, every major AI lab shipped an agent that sits in a team's Slack or Teams channel.
- Five coding products now let several people steer one live agent.
- Sequoia led Dust's $40M Series B, which was pitched as "multiplayer AI".

The evidence points to a narrower conclusion than the RFS. For most companies, the value of multiplayer isn't several people typing into one agent. It's making AI work **visible, forkable and credited** among peers. That is also how AI practice spreads, so multiplayer is the delivery mechanism for Commons' Layer C thesis.

Where the market is: five levels of "multiplayer"

LEVEL	WHO SHIPS IT (OCT 2026)	WHAT'S STILL MISSING
1 · Share a snapshot a read-only link	Claude Code on the web (Team visibility), claude.ai shared chats, Cursor shared transcripts (forkable), Devin session links	Nobody can *find* the good ones. You can't run it yourself. There's no record of who reused it.
2 · Shared context projects, spaces, memory	ChatGPT shared projects (up to 100 people)†, Claude Projects (view or edit), ChatGPT Space†, Dust, Mosaic (YC S26), Lore, PromptQL	The context is shared but the conversations aren't. In Claude Projects, chats aren't shared by default.
3 · Agent as a channel member	Claude Tag (one Claude per Slack channel), ChatGPT workspace agents, Teams Mode and channel agents, Gemini agents in Google Chat†, Slackbot, Lindy, Viktor, Runbear	Work is visible only inside one channel. There's no way to carry it to other teams or measure whether it spread.
4 · Live co-steering	Zed Delta, Amp Multiplayer, Slack Code, Linear coding sessions, AQ. **All of them are for coding.**	None for knowledge work. Mid-run handoff of ownership and billing is undefined.
5 · Shared skill libraries	Notion 3.7 Agent Skills, YC's open-source QM, Manus Project Skills, Figma, Workspace Studio, and native org skills at all four vendors	Ranking by whether colleagues kept using a skill, targeting it to the people who need it, and credit for the author.

Eight insights

1. **The last multiplayer wave made money from the people around the core user, through a link.** Two-thirds of Figma's 13M+ monthly users are non-designers. About 70% of new enterprise customers already had a Professional-plan user, and net dollar retention was 122–134% (S-1). For AI, the equivalent of Figma's free viewer is the colleague who watches a power user's run.
2. **AI is quietly shutting the channel that know-how used to travel through.** At Anthropic, 80–90% of questions now go to Claude, juniors ask seniors less, and human turns per session fell 33%. In a 2,234-person experiment, people paired with AI sent 18% fewer social messages to each other. Multiplayer is how that channel gets restored.
3. **Average gains come from people using AI alone. Breakthroughs come from groups using AI together.** At P&G (776 people), individuals with AI matched teams with AI on average quality (+0.37 vs +0.39 SD). But only teams with AI tripled their rate of top-10% solutions.
4. **Who is watching decides whether visibility helps.** Co-writers prefer seeing each other's prompts, and shared visibility made pairs less blindly reliant on AI. When an evaluator is watching, people using AI are judged lazier (PNAS, n=4,439), and visibility to evaluators cuts use by 14%. Share with peers by default, not with managers.
5. **Live co-steering is the hard 10%. Watching, commenting and forking are the useful 90%.** Instructions spread across turns cost LLMs about 39% in accuracy, and several steerers make that worse. Every product that works keeps one owner per run (Linear, GitHub, Claude Tag).
6. **The fork, not the library entry, is the unit of diffusion.** GitHub spreads code through forks and pull requests, and Figma through duplicated files. Claude can fork a session locally (`--fork-session`, SDK `forkSession`), but not someone else's, and nobody counts forks. A fork count is a ranking signal that is hard to game.
7. **Every extra viewer can mean less checking, unless one person is named as reviewer.** Inspectors working alongside a robot caught fewer of the defects it missed (3.30 vs 4.23). 40% of workers received AI "workslop" in the past month, mostly from peers.
8. **Long-running agents turn sessions into artifacts.** METR finds agent task length doubling about every 4 months since 2023. A run of several hours gets reviewed like a pull request, not watched like a chat. The thing to share is *goal → steps → output → outcome*.

> **What this means for Commons.** Commons should not build the live co-editing session. Anthropic, Slack, Zed and Linear are already building that layer. Commons should own what none of them do: **which runs are worth sharing, who should see them, whether colleagues forked them and kept using them, and who gets the credit.** The build order is run cards, then fork-to-my-skill, then a peer feed, then named reviewers. A live "watch" view comes last, on Claude Managed Agents, and only if forks show demand.

1 · What the last multiplayer wave teaches

PRODUCT	THE MULTIPLAYER MOVE	WHAT IT DID TO THE BUSINESS	LESSON FOR AI
Google Docs	Writely (2005) was share-instantly, real-time editing. Google bought it in 2006†.	Microsoft took about 10 years to respond. Live co-authoring reached desktop Word only in 2015, and only for files kept in OneDrive or SharePoint.	Multiplayer forces work into a shared store. AI runs have to leave the laptop before they can spread.
Figma	Multiplayer launched Sep 2016 with live cursors, follow mode, free view and comment access, and "the power of the URL".	Two-thirds of MAU are non-designers. About 70% of new Organization and Enterprise customers had a previous Pro user. Net dollar retention was 122% → 134% → 132%. From March 2025, seat upgrades need admin approval.	Growth is pulled in from the edges by viewers. Once spend gets large, admins take control back.
Slack	Team channels instead of email.	Teams that exchanged 2,000 messages were 93% retained†.	Activation is a property of the team, not the user. This matches the ~25% peer threshold in our Layer C brief.
GitHub	Fork plus pull request.	518.7M pull requests merged in 2025, up 29%†.	Anyone can reuse without asking, and changes still get reviewed.
Miro	Remote whiteboards during COVID.	5M → 30M users from 2020 to 2022. It later reportedly sold far below its peak valuation†.	Multiplayer adopted because of a crisis fades unless it becomes a habit.

2 · What research says about humans and AI working in groups

P&G "Cybernetic Teammate" (776 professionals; *Organization Science*, 2026)

The study compared 2×2 groups: individuals or R&D-plus-Commercial pairs, each with or without GPT-4. Quality gains over individuals without AI:

- Teams without AI: +0.24 SD
- Individuals with AI: +0.37 SD
- Teams with AI: +0.39 SD

Time spent fell 12.7–16.4%. Only teams with AI raised the rate of top-10% solutions, by 9.2 points on a 5.8% base. AI also erased the R&D vs Commercial split in the ideas people proposed. The authors say the tools "were not optimized for collaborative work".

So what: sell multiplayer as a way to get more breakthrough outcomes, not as average productivity.

AI replaces asking colleagues

Anthropic internal study (Dec 2025):

- Consecutive tool calls rose from 9.8 to 21.2.
- Human turns per session fell from 6.2 to 4.1.
- "80–90%" of questions now go to Claude.
- "Junior people don't come to me with questions as often."

Ju & Aral (MIT): 2,234 people made 11,024 ads. Human–AI pairs made 50% more ads, sent 18% fewer interpersonal messages, and delegated 17% more.

So what: the informal over-the-shoulder learning that spread software skills (Twidale, 2005) is drying up. Shared runs make a power user's work visible without anyone having to ask.

Visibility helps among peers

- **Triadic programming (N=20, 2026):** two people plus AI learned more than one person plus AI. They also relied less on AI's code, most of all when both could see the AI's work.
- **"Show Me Your Prompts!" (2026):** co-writers strongly preferred seeing each other's full prompts.
- **Microsoft New Future of Work 2025:** "Employees are more likely to experiment… and share… when they feel safe."

So what: share with peers by default and keep it opt-in. Managers see aggregates only.

…and has costs when the group gets bigger

- **Microsoft NFW 2025:** "AI currently works better for individuals than it does for teams." AI facilitators raised information sharing 22% but did not change group decisions.
- **Laban et al., ICLR 2026†:** accuracy drops about 39% when instructions arrive across several turns.
- **Social loafing with an automated partner (N=42):** people checked less carefully.
- **Workslop:** 40% of workers received some in the past month, mostly from peers.

So what: one owner per run, a named reviewer, and asynchronous before live.

The open question. We found no randomized study showing that watching a power user's agent run transfers skill better than a written skill or training. Commons has the telemetry to run that test and publish it (see page 5).

3 · Market map: about 50 products, grouped by what "multiplayer" means in each

COMPANY	WHAT IS ACTUALLY MULTIPLAYER	DATE · SIGNAL
INVESTOR THESES		
Y Combinator	Fall 2026 Request for Startups, "Multiplayer AI" (Epstein). YC also open-sourced **QM**, a multiplayer agent harness for Slack and the web. In QM, skills are owned by a scope (a person or a room), shared by granting access, and promoted to the whole org only with admin approval.	Fall 2026 · QM ~15k GitHub stars
a16z	Big Ideas 2026 (Immerman): vertical AI "goes multiplayer"; "the collaboration layer becomes the moat."	Dec 2025
MODEL PLATFORMS		
Anthropic	**Claude Tag**: one Claude per Slack channel. "Anyone can pick up the conversation where the last person left off." It has channel memory and is billed by usage. It replaced the per-user Slack app. Also: **multiplayer Artifacts**† (co-editing), and Projects with view or edit access. Claude Code web shares are **read-only snapshots**. GitHub issue #60082, asking for live multi-user sessions, has no reply from Anthropic.	Tag Jun 2026† · Artifacts Jul 2026†
OpenAI	Group chats (up to 20 people; personal memory not used)†. Shared projects (up to 100)†. Workspace agents, used together in ChatGPT or Slack, with approvals and handoffs†. **ChatGPT Space**, a shared home for Pages and files, plus "Dots", always-on agents†.	Nov 2025 → Sep/Oct 2026†
Microsoft	**Teams Mode** turns a 1:1 Copilot chat into a group chat. Channel agents. The Facilitator agent is generally available. Copilot Cowork: several users with one agent in a shared workspace†.	Nov 2025 · Apr 2026†
Google	Gemini Enterprise agents shared with groups and @-mentioned in Google Chat†. Workspace Studio skills "built together… as easily as collaborating on a Doc".	Apr 2026
CODING: THE ONLY PLACE LIVE CO-STEERING EXISTS		
Slack Code	A channel per agent task, with conversation, plan, diffs and preview. **Any member can pause or redirect the agent.** Deploys need human sign-off. Works with any vendor: Claude Code, Devin, Copilot, Codex, Vercel.	Aug 2026 · all Slack plans
Zed Delta	Invite teammates into an agent thread. Conversation and worktree replicate live. Comments on a line, diff or plan step steer the agent, and a teammate can "assume control".	Aug 2026 · private beta
Amp	Threads are visible to the workspace by default, with a team feed. @-mentioning a teammate turns on Multiplayer: they can prompt the agent and use its terminal. "Handoff" starts a new thread from distilled context.	2026
Linear	Delegating an issue starts a coding session. "Anyone can follow… redirect… or take over." The session belongs to the org, and the human stays the assignee.	Jun 2026
Cursor · Devin · GitHub	They share results, not live runs. Cursor has read-only, forkable transcripts and Projects (Sep 2026). Devin works through Slack threads. GitHub Agent HQ lets you steer an agent from mission control.	Cursor $3B ARR† · Cognition >$1B ARR†
Mosaic · Lore · AQ	**Mosaic** (YC S26) syncs Claude Code, Codex and Cursor sessions into shared team memory: about 2k installs and 37 orgs. **Lore**: `/lore:share` and `/lore:fork` turn a session into a team thread, and threads become a skills library. **AQ**: shared live terminals and one-click handoff, with 5,300+ workspaces.	2026 · closest to "the run as the unit"
TEAM-AGENT PLATFORMS AND DOCS		
Dust	Brands itself "multiplayer AI": agents share the same context, tools and skills as people, with permissions and agent analytics.	$40M Series B, May 2026 · 3,000+ orgs · 300k agents
Notion 3.7	**Agent Skills**: a workspace skills library that downloads to Claude Code, Codex and Cursor, with an "update available" badge.	Sep 2026 · nearest threat to our Skills tab
Glean · Gumloop · Tasklet · Lindy · Viktor · Runbear · Manus	Shared agents in Slack or Teams with team memory, shared skills and per-user auth. Manus has "Project Skills: turn your team's expertise into a reusable asset". Glean has agent identity: agents act as themselves.	Manus $100M ARR† · Viktor 67k teams (claimed)
Figma · Miro	Figma agent with team-shared skills. Miro Sidekicks reason on the canvas "so the entire team can see".	2026
VERTICALS: MULTIPLAYER MEANS SHARING ACROSS PARTIES		
Harvey · Legora · Hebbia	Shared Spaces and Vaults between a law firm and its client, with both sides approving permissions. Legora Portal. Hebbia: "turn individual AI work into firm-wide productivity" for deal teams.	Harvey $15.5B†
Day.ai · Intercom Fin · Hex · Granola	Day.ai: every agent reads and writes one shared context graph. Fin: handoff to a human with full context. Hex: multiplayer notebooks with agent tasks. Granola: team spaces.	Fin 2M resolutions per week

Not covered because the search budget ran out: Codegen, Tembo, v0, Lovable, Canva, Coda, Gamma, Writer, Sana, Rogo, Clay, Attio, Gong, Decagon, Otter and others. Treat this map as a strong sample, not a census.

4 · Seven multiplayer patterns, and where Claude stands on each

1 Snapshot	2 Feed	3 Comment	4 Fork	5 Assign	6 Channel	7 Co-steer
Share a read-only link	See the team's runs	Note on a step, for a person	Continue someone's run as yours	Agent works the issue; a human owns it	Agent as a member of the channel	Live, several hands, handoff

PATTERN	WHO DOES IT WELL	CLAUDE TODAY (FIRST-PARTY)	COMMONS OPPORTUNITY
1 Snapshot	Everyone	Yes. Claude Code web (Team visibility) and claude.ai chat share links are static, and recipients need repo access.	Index them: tag shared sessions to task clusters so they can be found
2 Feed	Amp (workspace-visible by default, team feed), Lore	**No.** There's no list of teammates' runs.	**Peer feed** of run cards, sideways and opt-in
3 Comment	Zed Delta, Figma, GitHub PRs	Partly. Diff comments go to Claude, not to a person.	Comments on a run card plus a **named reviewer**
4 Fork	Cursor transcripts, Lore `/lore:fork`, GitHub	Local and same-user only (`--fork-session`, `/branch`, SDK `forkSession`)	**"Fork into my skill"** with lineage. The fork count is a ranking signal.
5 Assign	Linear, GitHub Copilot agent, Codex cloud	Via integrations	Leave to the tools that hold the work items
6 Channel	Claude Tag, Slackbot, Teams channel agents	**Yes** (Claude Tag, public beta)	Read Tag usage by channel to turn recurring channel work into skills
7 Co-steer	Zed Delta, Amp, Slack Code, Linear, AQ (all coding)	**No.** Issue #60082 is open. Remote Control and teleport work for the same account only.	Later, on Managed Agents, if forks show demand

5 · Building blocks we can use now (verified in docs)

- **Hooks** receive `transcript_path`, so a command hook can turn the current session into a run card. Docs mention that "a SessionEnd hook can archive the transcript"; we haven't confirmed this.
- **Resume and fork:** `--resume <path>` accepts a `.jsonl` transcript, and `--fork-session` branches it. But the transcript format is internal and "changes between versions", so use `/export` or stream-JSON instead.
- **Agent SDK:** `forkSession`, plus a `SessionStore` adapter that mirrors transcripts to our backend "so another host can resume them".
- **Managed Agents** (beta): sessions live on the server, and any authorized client can post events to `/v1/sessions/{id}/events` to steer or interrupt. A `budget` cap is available. This is the cleanest base for a real shared live session. It isn't covered by zero data retention (ZDR) or HIPAA.
- **Claude Tag:** cost can be grouped by `slack_channel_id` and Tag category through the Analytics API (Enterprise).

6 · Gaps nobody fills yet

- **Cross-vendor live session.** Slack Code wraps several vendors' agents, but each run still belongs to one agent.
- **Mid-run handoff of ownership.** After a handoff, whose tokens, permissions and accountability apply? This is undefined almost everywhere.
- **Team memory with governance.** Each product keeps its own memory: per channel, per scope, or per repo. None has review or promotion rules for it.
- **Steer and approve rights.** Mostly just "share link" or "team". Amp's four visibility levels and Harvey's two-sided approvals are the most advanced.
- **Per-person attribution of agent output.** Which teammate's redirect or skill produced which part of the result?
- **Org-wide diffusion analytics.** Which shared runs and skills spread, to whom, and whether they stuck. **This is Commons' gap to own**, because hooks and telemetry already link runs to people and teams.

7 · How Commons goes multiplayer, in order

#	STEP	WHAT SHIPS	WHY THIS ORDER
M1	**Run cards** (`/commons:share-run`)	A command hook reads the transcript and drafts a card: goal, skill used, steps and tools, output type, outcome. Names, amounts and secrets are redacted, and the author previews the card before it goes out. It includes a **Run this yourself** button that copies the slash command or opens a prefilled session.	"Runnable beats taught." Claude's native shares are static, with no way to run them yourself.
M2	**Fork into my skill**	From any card, draft a personal skill that carries a `derived_from` link. The upstream author gets credit when forkers are still using it after 30 days.	The fork is the unit of diffusion, and it's hard to game
M3	**Circles and a peer feed**	Opt-in groups of 3–15 people. Run cards stay inside the circle unless the author widens them. Shows a team threshold bar, e.g. "4 of 11 have run this".	Adoption tips over in clusters (~25%). Peers see the work; evaluators don't.
M4	**Comments and a named reviewer**	Comments on a step, addressed to a person. A shared run that feeds a deliverable must name a reviewer.	Prevents loafing and workslop
M5	**Channel work → skill candidates**	Recurring Claude Tag categories per channel go into the Suggested queue.	Work done in channels is already visible, so peers can see it without a share step
M6	**Watch live** (later)	A read-only live view of a Managed Agents run, with "take over" for the owner only.	Only once M2 fork data shows people want it. Anthropic may ship it natively.

The experiment that makes this a category

For a skill that has a good run card, randomize colleagues in the target cluster into three groups for 14 days:

A. See the teammate's **run card**.

B. See only the **SKILL.md** listing.

C. See nothing (holdback).

Measure first runs within 14 days and use that is still going at day 30. If A beats B, "watch and fork" is shown to transfer skill, which no published study has done yet. That result becomes the sales story and a research paper.

Metrics for multiplayer

- **Forks per shared run**, and the share of forkers still using it at day 30
- **Sideways share rate:** the share of run cards opened by peers outside the author's own team
- **Time from a power user's first run to the fifth colleague's run** (diffusion speed)
- Never shown: raw views, raw runs, or individual leaderboards

8 · Risks and guardrails

RISK	EVIDENCE	GUARDRAIL
Being watched suppresses use	57% hide their AI use. Visibility to evaluators cuts use 14%. People seen using AI are judged lazier.	Peer-only and opt-in by default. Managers see aggregates of 5+ people. Authors choose to widen.
Data and credentials leak through shared runs	Sharing a Gemini Gem shares its files. Public Claude sessions "may contain… credentials".	Redact before sharing, author preview, repo-access check, and a list of the connectors each run used
Cost of long or shared runs	Claude Code averages about $13 per developer per active day. Agent teams use about 7× the tokens.	Show expected cost on each card. Use the Managed Agents `budget` cap for live runs.
Platform absorbs it	Anthropic already shipped Tag, multiplayer Artifacts and team-visible sessions. Notion and QM ship skill libraries.	Own what platforms won't do: cross-team targeting, retention, lineage and credit. Use native sharing for transport.
"Multiplayer AI" is a crowded marketing term	At least 8 vendors used it as positioning by Q3 2026.	Position as "AI practice that spreads". Multiplayer is how it spreads, not the brand.

Key sources (full list: research/multiplayer-ai-sources.md):

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Dust Series B blog

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